ONLINE STORE · VEHICLE WORKFLOW GUIDE

Part 1

What an online store actually is

Behind every “Add to cart” there are six moving parts. Knowing them lets you choose a provider in an afternoon, know what you are paying for, and see exactly where your Blender work plugs in.

In this part

1. The six moving parts of a store
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Revenue splits, fee ranges and the “Personal Depot” concept are from the supplied opportunity analysis; provider names are examples current at the time of writing and their fees must be checked on their own pricing pages.

1 · The six moving parts of a store

① Catalogue
products: title, price, images, text, the file to deliver, version

② Cart and checkout
collects items, address for tax, applies discount codes

③ Payment gateway
card / PayPal / Apple Pay; fraud checks; pays out to your bank

④ Delivery
secure download link, licence key, re-downloads, version history

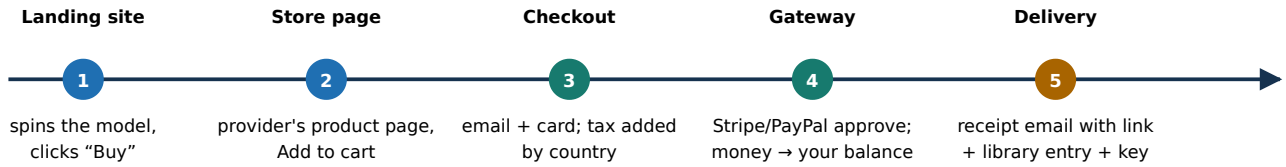
⑤ Accounts and email
customer library, receipts, update announcements, password resets

⑥ Taxes and compliance
VAT/sales tax per country, invoices, refund handling, GDPR notices

Only ① is yours to write. ②–⑥ come as one package from a storefront provider. Trying to build them is the classic solo-creator trap.

Figure 1.1 · The six parts. "Digital delivery" (④) is the one that matters most for software: the provider generates a unique, expiring link per sale and keeps the file available in the customer's library for re-downloads after your updates.

2 · What happens when someone buys



Later

You upload v1.1 of the installer → the provider emails every buyer "update available" → they re-download from their library.

A refund request → you approve in the dashboard → gateway reverses the charge → the download is revoked. Payout to your bank: typically weel

Figure 1.2 · The purchase, end to end. Note that steps 2–5 happen on the provider's pages. Your landing site only has to get the visitor to step 2 convinced, which is what the 3D viewer is for.

3 · Three ways to run a store, compared

	A · Hosted creator store Gumroad, Payhip, Lemon Squeezy, itch.io	**B · Hosted shop platform** Shopify + digital-download app	**C · Self-built** WooCommerce on your own hosting, or custom code
Set-up effort	An afternoon. Upload file, write page, connect bank.	A weekend. Theme, app for downloads, domain.	Weeks, plus ongoing maintenance and security updates.
Digital delivery	Built in: links, keys, library, update emails.	Via an app (SendOwl, Sky Pilot, Digital Downloads). check	Plugin or your code.

	A · Hosted creator store Gumroad, Payhip, Lemon Squeezy, itch.io	B · Hosted shop platform Shopify + digital-download app	C · Self-built WooCommerce on your own hosting, or custom code
Taxes (EU VAT, US sales tax)	Many act as **merchant of record**: they collect and remit for you. check per provider	Tools exist; you are usually the merchant.	You.
Fees	≈ 5–10% + payment fees	Monthly plan + app + payment fees	Hosting + payment fees (≈ 3%)
Look and feel	Limited; but your landing site is fully yours and links in.	Themeable; the 3D viewer can be embedded as a custom section.	Anything.
Pre-orders / memberships	Mostly built in (pre-orders, memberships, pay-what-you-want).	Via apps.	Your code.
Risk	Provider policy changes; export your customer list regularly.	Low.	Breaches and downtime are yours to fix.
Who it suits	**You, now.**	You, once the catalogue is 10+ products and bundles/upsells matter.	Not a Blender generalist's best use of time.

The opportunity analysis recommends Shopify or WooCommerce with Stripe/PayPal and a delivery plugin; that is route B/C. For a first launch with a handful of products, route A gets the same customer experience (link, library, updates) with far less to run, and the landing site makes it look bespoke anyway. Moving from A to B later is a product-by-product re-upload, not a rebuild.

4 · The recommended setup for a solo creator

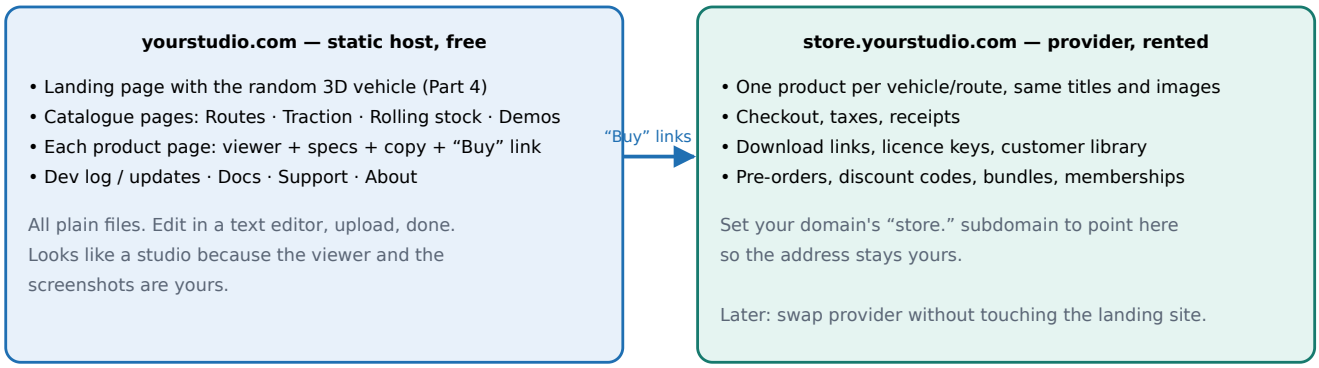


Figure 1.3 · Recommended split. Everything a visitor sees first is yours; everything that touches money is rented. The provider's pages carry your logo and colours so the hand-off is not jarring.

5 · The customer's “Personal Depot”

The analysis calls for an account area where a buyer sees lifetime re-downloads and which products just received a framework patch. Every provider in route A already gives buyers a library page with their purchases and versions; you get the “depot” by:

- naming it so on your site (a “My depot” link in the menu that points at the provider's library login), and
- using the provider's **update** feature when you re-upload a product: buyers get the email, the library shows the new version.

What you do not get on route A is a cross-product dashboard of your own design (“three of your locos use framework v2.3”). Keep that as a page on the landing site: a **Compatibility board** listing each product, its current version and the framework version it needs. Static text, updated by you with each release.

6 · Where the 3D viewer sits

- **Landing page hero:** a random vehicle from the pool, full-width, with the hotspot buttons. This is the “proof of mastery” moment. demo
- **Product pages on your site:** the same viewer with that product's model only; buttons for its signature features (“Line breaker”, “Trolley pole”, “Cab doors”).
- **Provider's product page:** usually images and video only. Some providers allow an embedded iframe or custom HTML check; otherwise link back to your product page (“Interactive preview ↗”).
- **Dev log posts:** drop the viewer with a work-in-progress model to show progress on a crowdfunded project.

7 · Costs, fees and what you keep

Item	Typical	Notes
Domain	$10–20 / year	Registrar of your choice; point “www” at the static host and “store” at the provider.
Static hosting	$0	Free tiers of Netlify, Cloudflare Pages, GitHub Pages, Vercel cover a landing site with a few hundred MB of models. check bandwidth limits.
Storefront provider fee	≈ 5–10% of each sale	Often includes payment processing; otherwise add ≈ 3% + $0.30.
Payment gateway	≈ 3% + $0.30	Stripe / PayPal; sometimes bundled into the provider fee.
Taxes on income	per the analysis: ≈ 27–28% federal + self-employment in the US (0% state in Texas)	Not legal or tax advice; confirm with an accountant.

Item	Typical	Notes
Tools	≈ $1,500 over a project	The analysis's operating budget (texturing suites, hosting, archival fees).
What you keep	≈ 85–93% of gross before income tax	Versus 30–50% via Steam partnership (analysis, “Comparing the two paths”).

8 · Decision checklist

✓	Decide	Default if unsure
☐	Provider for checkout and delivery	A hosted creator store that handles tax as merchant of record
☐	Static host for the landing site	Any free static host with drag-and-drop deploy
☐	Domain name and the two subdomains	`www.` → host, `store.` → provider
☐	Business name on receipts and the legal footer	Your studio name; design names for products (Part 2)
☐	Delivery format	Installer (.exe) for TSC products, zip for TF3 mods; both versioned
☐	First product and first demo	A $10 micro-route or a single loco, plus a free “proving ground” (analysis Wave 4)
☐	Support channel	Email address on the site + a forum thread or Discord